This chapter will assist you in preparing and writing memos that allow you to communicate effectively in today's workplace.

The first section explains the basic structure of a memo. The second section offers examples of the most common types of business memos. It concludes by giving you a checklist to keep in mind when writing memos.

Definition of a Memo

A memo is a document typically used for communication within a company.

The Basic Structure of a Memo

1. Heading
2. Purpose
3. Body
4. Conclusion
5. Closing
6. Carbon Copy "CC"

The basic structure of a memo is discussed in the following pages and illustrated in Figure 2.1 in section 6.

1. Heading

The heading section follows this general format:

To:	readers' names or job titles
From:	your name or job title
Date:	current date is always included (e.g., February 6, 20xx)
Subject:	what the memo is about (be specific)



Different companies may use other heading formats than the one which appears here; use whichever format your company prefers.

2. Purpose

The purpose section provides a brief statement to direct your reader to the purpose of your memo.



Example:

- We refer to your memo dated May 23, 20xx regarding the organization's update.
- Attached, as requested, is an updated training record for our trainees.
- It has been noticed that some employees are still smoking in the main office.
- All supervisors will meet June 3, 20xx at 10:00 a.m. to work out the annual operating budgets for all departments.

3. Body

The body section explains your request or response. It provides additional details to support the purpose statement.



Example:

To: Human Resources Manager
From: Head of Employee Relations
Date: September 5, 20xx
Subject: New Employees

Two new employees have been hired to work in the Human Resources Department. Lila Hamdi will begin work on October 1, and Yassin Ali will begin on October 15.

Ms. Lila has worked for three years as an administrative assistant for another company. Due to her previous experience, she was hired as a Program Assistant.

Mr. Yassin has just completed a one-year training program at Gulf Community College. He was hired as an Administrative Assistant.

Body

I would like to introduce you to the new employees. Please schedule a time for a short visit.

4. Conclusion

The conclusion section reiterates the goal of the memo, and states any action required.



Examples:

- Your feedback on the attached proposal by May 10 would be appreciated.
- Please contact me if you require further information.
- Your cooperation in this regard is appreciated.
- I would appreciate your comments on this matter by March 20, xx.
- I look forward to receiving your approval on this matter.

5. Closing

The most common closings are:

- Sincerely,
- Yours sincerely,
- Regards,

6. Carbon copy "CC"

If your memo needs to be distributed, then list those people who should have a copy for their information only under "cc", but do not expect them to take any action.

	Memorandum
1 Heading	To: readers' names or job titles From: your name or job title Date: current date Subject: what the memo is about (be specific)
2 Purpose	In paragraph one, state the point or main idea of your memo.
3 Body	In paragraph two, provide the explanation and background data to support your point if required.
4 Conclusion	In paragraph three, conclude your memo with an action statement by telling your readers exactly what you want them to do.
5 Closing	Regards, Name Job Title
6 Carbon Copy	CC:

Figure 2.1 The basic structure of a memo



Example

Memorandum

1 **Heading**	To: Operation Supervisor From: Transport Supervisor Date: May1, 2003 Subject: Renewal of Driver's License
2 **Purpose**	Our records indicate that your driver's license will expire on July 30, 20xx.
3 **Body**	Please submit the following documents before May 15, 20xx in order to complete the processing formalities: • Three sets of clear passport photocopies • Two recent passport size photographs.
4 **Conclusion**	Your cooperation in this regard would be appreciated.
5 **Closing**	Regards, Amar Ahmed Transport Supervisor
6 **Carbon Copy**	CC: Head of Transport

Common types of memos

Memos are frequently used:

1. To inform

To provide information without necessarily expecting any action on the part of your readers.



Example:

To: Head of Department
From: Mechanical Engineer
Date: March 5, 20xx
Subject: Absence from duty

This is to inform you that I was unable to report for work on Tuesday and Wednesday of last week due to an illness that kept me confined to bed.

A medical certificate from the hospital is attached for your files.
Regards,

Khalid Ali
Mechanical Engineer

2. To request

To obtain permission, information, approval, help, or assistance.



Example:

To: Head of Maintenance
From: Senior Mechanical Engineer
Date: September 15, 20xx
Subject: Maintenance Management course

I am interested in attending the above mentioned course, which will be held at the Hilton Hotel in Dubai from December 8–12, 20xx.

This course will certainly enhance my knowledge of the subject and help me meet the maintenance challenges of our department.

Your approval would be greatly appreciated.
Regards,

Lila Hamad
Senior Mechanical Engineer

3. To instruct

To give information in the form of directions, instructions, or procedures.



Example:

To: All Employees
From: ABC Plant Manager
Date: April 16, 20xx
Subjec: Private Vehicles

In order to minimize road traffic accidents, employees bringing private vehicles to ABC plants are requested to adhere to the following regulations:

1. All private vehicles should be parked inside the accommodation complex.
2. Company transportation must be used for any work within the plant.

Your strict adherence to the above will be much appreciated.
Regards,

Jassim Hansen
ABC Plant Manager

4. To recommend

Suggesting an action or series of actions based on alternative possibilities that have been evaluated.



Example:

To: Head of Safety
From: Senior Safety Engineer
Date: March 5, 20xx
Subject: Reverse Parking Sensor

It has been noticed that the number of accidents being reported as a result of reverse parking has increased in the past three months.

Therefore, it is recommended that sensors be installed on company vehicles to prevent further accidents.
Regards,

Hala Ali
Senior Safety Engineer

5. To respond

To act in response to your superior's questions about something related to your work. Also, you may respond to a previous communication.



Example 1

To: All Employees
From: Human Resources Manager
Date: March 5, 20xx
Subject: Smoking Policy

In response to many suggestions by employees throughout the company, we have developed a company policy that permits smoking only in **designated smoking rooms**.

This policy applies to both employees and visitors to our office. If you have any questions please contact Ali in personnel services on extension 22555.

Regards,
Khaled Hamdi
Human Resources Manager



Example 2

To: Mechanical Supervisor
From: Team Leader
Date: March 5, 20xx
Subject: Business Writing Course

In reply to your memo dated March 10, 20xx regarding the abovementioned subject, I am glad to inform you that your request has been approved.

Please contact the training coordinator to make the necessary arrangement.

Regards,
Amar Jassim
Team Leader

6. To complain

To express disapproval of an unsatisfactory situation.



Example

To: Technical Support Manager
From: Head of Maintenance
Date: June 10, 20xx
Subject: Compressor Failure

We are having frequent failures with the two valves installed recently in our gas facility. The problem has caused a severe decline in our production rate.

I would appreciate having someone from your company come and take an in-depth look at this problem.

Please let me know if you need more information.
Regards,

Mohamed Hansen
Head of Maintenance

7. To remind

To remind your employees about things which have to be completed or that have not been followed up appropriately.



Example

To: All Employees
From: Head of Planning
Date: July 10, 20xx
Subject: Use of copier

It has been noticed that some employees in this department are using copiers for other than company business.

All employees are therefore requested to limit the use of copies to company business only.

Your cooperation in this matter is appreciated.

Lila Ali
Head of Planning

8. To show appreciation

To show appreciation and gratitude for a job particularly well done.



Example 1

To: Team Leader Power
From: Plant Manager
Date: July 15, 20xx
Subject: Letter of appreciation

I am pleased to convey the management's appreciation for your active role and prompt response in getting our operations back to normal.

You have displayed valuable professional skills and dedication to your duties which are particularly noteworthy.

We rely upon your continued support in any such future emergencies.

Adel Hassan
Plant Manager



Example 2

To: Team Leader Power
From: Plant Manager
Date: July 15, 20xx
Subject: Letter of appreciation

We are pleased to inform you that you have been selected "Safety Employee of the Month" for raising your concerns about water coolers at ABC restaurants and suggesting a safe method.

Please accept a gift together with this letter as a token of the Management's appreciation.

Adel Hassan
Plant Manager

Summary

Remember the following top ten points when you write memos:

1. Use the proper memorandum format that your company prefers.
2. Use a specific subject line that summarizes the memo clearly.
3. Use short, simple sentences.
4. Focus each paragraph on one idea related to the subject.
5. Check spelling when the document is complete.
6. Identify yourself clearly.
7. Think of your reader.
8. Write it all on one page.
9. Keep it simple.
10. Keep a copy of all correspondence for future reference.